

Microsoft LifeCam VX-6000, which has 1.3 MP at 1280 x 960.

In the Notebook category, 640 x 480 was the common resolution, except for the Genius VideoCAM Eye, which offered a maximum resolution of just 352 x 288. Video resolutions are naturally more important than still, because webcams are mainly used for video chats.



Genius Look 312P
Play with me!

Still photography is available in all webcams today. However, the webcam is never going to be a replacement for your digital camera. The maximum still resolution available was by the Microsoft LifeCam VX-6000—a whopping 5.0 megapixels. The Microsoft LifeCam VX-3000, Logitech QuickCam, and Genius Look 312P and 315FS had a 1.3 MP (1280x960) resolution. The Creative WebCam Live! had a resolution of 1024 x 768, while the rest couldn't offer any more than

a VGA resolution of 640 x 480.

Amongst the Notebook webcams, the Logitech QuickCam for Notebooks Deluxe offered the highest resolution of 1.3 MP. The Genius VideoCAM Messenger and the Logitech QuickCam Image both had 1280 x 960. The other two could only manage 640 x 480.

Audio Features

Even though you can use your PC's sound card to connect a microphone for voice chats, many webcams these days feature an inbuilt microphone. Similarly, many webcams come with a earpiece-microphone combo, thus offering a complete video-chat solution. In the PC category, only the Creative WebCam Live! and Logitech QuickCam IM came with a headset-microphone pair, apart from an inbuilt microphone. The Tech-Com SSD-640K and the Logitech QuickCam Go, both of which are entry-level models, featured none of the audio features. The Logitech QuickCam Chat had a headset-microphone set, but no inbuilt microphone. The rest came with only an inbuilt microphone. In the Notebook category, all the webcams had in-built audio. The Genius VideoCam Messenger also came with a microphone, which you can connect to your PC's sound card.

Optical Features

Auto-focusing is a feature that is yet to make a mark in webcam products. There are a few

webcams that can do this, but none that are available in India. Instead, all of them came with a manual focusing mechanism—a focusing ring around the lens. The Logitech Orbit MP, which we have reviewed separately, did feature auto-focus, but was not part of the test.

Zoom is another feature that is not common in a webcam. This feature is useful when the subject sits at a distance and wants to occupy a larger portion of the image canvas. Though optical zoom is available in some webcams, those that came to us featured only digital zoom through the accompanying software. In the PC category, the

Genius 312P and 315FS and Microsoft's LifeCam VX-3000 and VX-6000 supported digital zoom, while from the



Tech-Com SSD-641-MP
The underdog that won it!

How We Tested

The computer used to test the webcams comprised an Intel Pentium 4 processor running at a stock clock speed of 3.6 GHz on an Intel Original 925XCV motherboard. 1 GB of Micron DDR2 RAM at 533 MHz was used, and the hard disk was a Seagate Barracuda 120 GB SATA. A fresh copy of Windows XP SP2 was installed along with the latest version of DirectX. The latest drivers for the various hardware components were loaded. The latest drivers for each webcam were loaded, too.

The webcams were evaluated on three parameters—Featured, Performance and Price. Each parameter had different weightage, based on what was considered important for the average user.

Features

Points were awarded based on the various features: maximum sensor capacity for video and still images; automatic, manual or fixed focus; zoom capabilities; audio capture; headset / microphone provided; a snapshot button; swivel; length of cable;

stands provided; and more. The bundled software, how easy they were to use, the features they offered, and support for different operating systems were also noted. Face tracking, noise cancellation, etc. were awarded bonus points if available. We also allocated points for build quality and aesthetics.

Performance

We tested the webcams for their video quality under two different lighting conditions—fluorescent and daylight. For the fluorescent lighting test, a tubelight was lit, and the video image quality of the webcam was noted. We placed the subject and webcams near a window for the daylight test. In both cases, the colour reproduction, image brightness and contrast, as well as sharpness were noted, and rated on a scale of 5.

At the end of it all, price was taken into consideration. Features, Performance and Price all contributed towards deciding the Digit Best Buy Gold and Digit Best Buy Silver winners.